

▶ WESTERN GHATS

THE OTHER SIDE IS NOT GREENER

The seventh edition of the Madhav Gadgil plan to save the Western Ghats, although much abbreviated, still faces state scissors

By **Jumana Shah**

THE BARGAIN IS SIMPLE. THERE LIES A LONG band of forest, emerald-green and falling like the *pallu* of a saree, all along India's west coast. Once spanning 160,000 square kilometres, with all the embroidery of nature that cannot be reproduced, it has already shrunk to about half that size. Would you keep the remaining half? Or instead have it crawling with quarries, wind turbines, plantations, exotic real estate, and bypasses that will soon need more bypasses for fat SUVs to reach them? After 13 years and six lapsed drafts, India has yet to decide.

The seventh draft notification is expiring on September 25. Six state governments have a say, and at least two seem in a mood to tear up the draft. The others are building sly bypasses within it. Environmentalists are going around desperately pleading with the public to step in and help protect India's biodiversity. There's another stakeholder in the mix that they don't always count: a human population that's estimated at about 5.2 million. They are ordinarily resident in the 1,600-km chain of hills running from Gujarat to Kerala, a range older than the Himalaya. The Western Ghats are called one of the world's eight 'hottest hotspots' of biodiversity. They call it home.

A GREEN UMBRELLA

Since 2014, the Union environment ministry has attempted to protect the Ghats by notifying them as an Eco-Sensitive Area (ESA). That would bring the zone under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986. Activities most damaging for the ecology would be banned or tightly regulated. No new mines or quarries, thermal power plants, red-category polluting industries or construction with a built-up area above 20,000 sq. m. Today, the Ghats are protected only where the state owns the land: sanctuaries, tiger reserves and recorded forest. Quarrying, hill-cutting, homestays...and monster landslides, all these happen on private and revenue land. Only a central ESA notification can reach those ravaged portions.

The key challenge in imposing ESA? The six states, in varying degrees of opposition and partial acquiescence. Karnataka is furthest out: it has declared that it will formally reject the draft. Farmers in its Malnad region have staged protests, demanding a ground survey to exclude human settlements. Kerala, the other state with the most resource entanglement in the Ghats, wants its boundaries shrunk—keeping out Idukki and the Cardamom Hills. Goa is worried that an ESA tag would cramp local tourism, farming and real estate development and wants 21 villages exempted. The other three states have ostensibly accepted the draft, but with caveats. Tamil Nadu's mapping seems to ingeniously exclude vulnerable private/revenue land, Maharashtra wants to keep out 378 villages that would substantially alter the ESA's footprint and Gujarat is seeking exceptions for mining within the zone.

DRAFT, REDRAFT

The expert committee whose job it is to reconcile the objections—headed by former Director General of Forests Sanjay Kumar—has got a year's extension running up to July 2027. "It is at an advanced level of talks. We are hopeful all six states will come on board," says a source in the ministry. That sounds ambitious, given the tortured history the proposal has lived through.

The previous six drafts emerged from two committees. In 2011, the